control over the Afghan Taliban and then get them to talk to Kabul, it was failing miserably. Soon after becoming the chief, Mansour made a statement seeking a continuation of armed attacks in Afghanistan.[20] The intensity of the blast and the high number of casualties broke the fragile but developing Afghanistan-Pakistan bilateral relationship. In a public address, Ghani caustically told his eastern neighbour:

> In the middle of the night, at 1:30 a.m., doomsday descended upon our people. It wasn't an earthquake, it wasn't a storm, it was human hand ... I ask the people and the government of Pakistan: If a massacre such as the one that occurred in Shah Shaheed had happened in Islamabad and the perpetrators had sanctuaries in Afghanistan, had offices and training centers in our major cities, how would you react?[21]

Was there an implicit threat in Ghani's statement? The answer to this question will become clearer in the coming months or years. Having (strategically and patiently) waited for Ghani's outreach towards Pakistan to fail, New Delhi proactively stepped in. To underline support for Afghanistan, Modi launched the much-awaited and long-delayed Salma Dam in June 2016 (called the India-Afghanistan Friendship Dam). In a powerful speech marking the timelessness of India-Afghanistan relations, Modi made his intent about Pakistan, without naming the country, amply clear. 'It was a war not of Afghan making, but it was one that stole the future of an entire generation of Afghans ... India will not forget you or turn away ... your friendship is our honour, your dreams our duty'.[22] Conciliation had not worked to secure India's security interests in Afghanistan, or to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan. The conditions for a partisan comeback were ripe, and Modi, with support from his advisors, had done just that by raking up human rights violations in Balochistan and Pakistan-administered Kashmir.

India's approach towards Afghanistan is not simply about fighting proxy wars with Pakistan. Yes, India finds it expedient to politically harass Pakistan via Afghanistan (and vice versa), but this is not the long-term goal. The aim is to ensure balance between its two neighbours wherein neither of them has an overbearing influence on the domestic polity of the other. Despite its close relations with Daoud Khan in the 1970s, for instance, India was wary of his forward policy on Pashtunistan and refused him support for fear of dividing Pakistan. Though New Delhi did not substantially criticise the Soviet